

It is very important to read all instructions before collecting your water samples. Learn more and watch a video about testing your drinking water at www.healthvermont.gov/water.

Your kit comes with

- Four bottles: (1) 1-liter plastic bottle, (1) 500-milliliter plastic bottle, (1) 250-milliliter plastic bottle, and (1) 100-milliliter plastic bottle. The smallest plastic bottle contains a preservative; do not rinse this bottle.
- Freezer packs (unfrozen)
- Cooler for returning samples

Prepare

- Read Sample Return Instructions carefully; **this kit must be analyzed within 30 hours of collection.**
- Put the freezer packs in the freezer ahead of time.
- Wash and sanitize your hands prior to filling the bottles.
- Do not touch the inside of the caps or mouths of the bottles.
- Do not rinse the bottles.
- Fill the plastic bottles with water on the same day that you will submit them for testing.
- The First Draw Lead bottle (250-mL) must be filled first, then the remaining 3 bottles can be filled in any order.



Collect First Draw Lead (medium plastic bottle, 250 mL)



- Do not use any water from the faucet you are testing for at least 8 hours. Tip: collect sample first thing in the morning.
- Do not remove the faucet aerator when you collect this sample.
- Place the medium 250 mL opened bottle below the faucet **before** turning on the water.
- Turn cold water on slowly and catch all water in the bottle.
- Fill the bottle to the line and screw the cap on tightly.

Collect the Other Samples (bacteria, gross alpha, inorganic chemicals)

- With clean hands, remove the sink aerator.
- Run cold water at **high flow for 3-5 minutes** to get rid of water that has been sitting in your pipes. If you have a single-handle faucet, run hot water for 2 minutes, then cold water for 2 minutes.
- Reduce the flow by half to collect your water samples.
- Fill the bottles to the neck and screw the caps on tightly. Do not fill past the neck of the bottles.



Homeowner's Testing Package – How to Collect Water Samples (continued)

Return Your Samples to the Laboratory



- Complete all **Water Sample Collection Information Forms**, including the date and time you took each water sample.
 - If you use any water treatment in your water, describe it on the form (for example: water softener).
 - If treatment was bypassed or turned off, write “bypass treatment” in the sampler’s comment section.
 - Label the sample bottles with your name, faucet location, and phone number so it can be matched with its correct form (for example: John Schmidt, kitchen sink, 802-XXX-XXXX).
 - Put frozen freezer packs and the tightly closed bottles in a cooler with the completed forms. We suggest putting the forms inside a sealed plastic bag.
- **Read Sample Return Instructions carefully, this kit must be analyzed within 30 hours of collection.**

Frequently Asked Questions

When can I expect my test results?

Bacteria results are released within 1-2 business days. The other results are typically available within 18 calendar days. To avoid mail delays, write your email address on the sample collection information forms.

How often should I test my water?

Recommended Frequency	Test Package ID	Kits Included	Analytes in Package
Annually	Bacteria	Kit A	Coliform, <i>E. Coli</i>
Every 5 Years	Homeowner’s Testing Package	Kits A, RA, C, first draw lead	Coliform, <i>E. Coli</i> , gross alpha, trace metals, inorganics, first draw lead

How can I make sure I send a sample that is acceptable for testing?

Sometimes we receive samples that need to be “qualified,” which means the sample did not meet all the testing requirements. **Here are a few things you can do to submit an acceptable drinking water sample:**

- We must analyze your samples within 30 hours of collection. Be sure the bottles get to the laboratory shortly after you fill them.
- Use freezer packs and a cooler to keep the temperature of your samples less than 42 °F (6 °C) – cold but not freezing – until it reaches the laboratory.
- Make sure each bottle is filled to the neck. Only use bottles provided by our laboratory.



Scan this QR code to see a video on how to sample your water for bacteria or go to this link: <https://youtu.be/a1DJffO0gCA>.

Go to: HealthVermont.gov/drinking-water-sample-drop-information for online sample drop-off information.